



Introductory Questions

A guide to journeys, endings, thresholds, false arrivals, and the difficult art of deciding when "there" has been reached

The question inside the question

"Are we there yet?" sounds like a request for distance. A child in the back seat wants a number of minutes or kilometres. Yet the person driving often hears several other questions: How much longer must I wait? Is the route working? Can I trust the person in charge? Will the destination be worth the discomfort? The 2026 theme begins with this ordinary exchange because it contains the whole problem in miniature. A journey has a destination, but it also has expectations, costs, measurements, detours, and people with unequal knowledge of the route.

The official prompts move quickly between a road trip, a song, a film, adolescence, abandoned technologies, unfinished games, university completion, group projects, product launches, and diminishing returns. Those are not disconnected icebreakers. Each changes one part of the same model. Sometimes "there" is a place. Sometimes it is a deadline, an identity, a finished story, a market-ready product, or a point beyond which continuing produces too little value. Sometimes arrival is real but disappointing. Sometimes the destination changes while we are moving. Sometimes stopping is wiser than finishing.

The linked pages and videos are part of that curriculum. They provide the evidence hidden behind the short prompts: what the multiple endings of *The Return of the King* actually finish, why nuclear cars failed, why a meal cannot be compressed into a tiny pill, and why completion statistics need careful interpretation. Read each link for its mechanism, not for a line of trivia. The useful habit for the entire year is to ask four questions: what is moving, what counts as progress, who decides that the journey is complete, and what remains unfinished after the declared arrival?

Chapter 1 - Different kinds of "there"

The opening prompt begins with a saying usually translated as "A journey of a thousand miles begins beneath one's feet" or "with a single step." The familiar version is associated with the *Daodejing*, traditionally connected to Laozi. Its popularity can make the first step sound heroic. Starting matters, but the WSC prompt deliberately asks the neglected question: how does the journey end? A first action can be dramatic and visible while the long middle depends on routine, support, revision, and the willingness to continue.

Arrival is a rule, not only a location

Physical travel offers an apparently easy answer. If a map marks Taipei Main Station, arrival occurs when the train reaches the platform. Even here, definitions multiply. Has a passenger arrived when the train crosses the city boundary, when the doors open, when they leave the station, or when they meet the person waiting outside? The correct answer depends on the purpose of the journey. A transport operator, a worried parent, and a parcel-tracking system can use different endpoints without any of them lying.

Non-physical journeys make the rule more visible. A school year ends on an official date, but a student may feel it ending after the last examination, the farewell ceremony, or the moment friends stop seeing one another every day. A friendship may have no ceremony at all. One person can think it is over while the other believes it is merely quiet. A group project can be "done" when a file is submitted even though one member still sees errors. In each case, arrival depends on a convention: an agreed sign that the next state has begun.

This explains why knowing that an ending is near changes experience. Scarcity can sharpen attention. The last week of school may make an ordinary lunch feel important because it cannot be repeated in the same form. A known deadline can also produce anxiety, rushing, avoidance, or conflict. An unexpected ending reverses the problem: there was no time to prepare a final conversation or revise the meaning of what came before. Strong answers should therefore separate the objective schedule from the emotional threshold.

The destination can fail its own test

Getting somewhere does not prove that going there was worthwhile. Travellers can reach an attraction and discover that the queue, price, weather, or reality does not match the imagined destination. A student can win a position and dislike the work attached to it. A company can launch a product that customers do not need. This is regret after arrival: the route succeeded under one measure but failed under a larger purpose.

The idea also challenges the phrase "it is not the destination, it is the journey," often attributed to Ralph Waldo Emerson without reliable evidence. Sometimes the destination does dominate. A rescue team, vaccine shipment, or ambulance cannot replace arrival with an enjoyable route. At other times the route creates the value. A walk, conversation, education, or friendship would be diminished if it were compressed to its final certificate. The wise answer is not to choose journey or destination in every case. It is to identify what the activity is for.

Detours complicate the choice. A place between the planned beginning and end can become worthwhile in its own right. That can be serendipity, but it can also be a change of goal. If a research question leads to a more interesting discovery, continuing toward the original answer merely because it was written first may be irrational. "Are we there yet?" sometimes needs a second question: is "there" still where we want to go?

Different travellers may answer differently because they bear different costs. A family driver sees fuel, traffic, safety, and the entire route; a passenger sees discomfort in the present. A company celebrates launch while support workers inherit unresolved defects. A school reaches its target average while some students remain far from the promised outcome. An arrival claim becomes stronger when it identifies whose journey the measure represents and whose unfinished distance has been averaged away.

Progress, launch, and diminishing returns

Business turns these philosophical problems into decisions. A product is rarely perfect at launch. Waiting for every possible improvement may allow a competitor to move first or may consume money without adding much value.

Launching too early can expose users to danger, broken promises, or an unfinished service. Teams therefore use thresholds: a minimum safe and useful version, a quality target, a regulatory approval, or evidence that further testing has sharply smaller benefits.

This is the logic of diminishing returns. If one more hour of study raises an expected score substantially, continuing may be worthwhile. After many hours without rest, the next hour may add little and could even damage performance. Diminishing returns do not mean that the total result is shrinking; they mean that each additional unit of input produces a smaller additional gain. The distinction matters. A student should not stop because progress has slowed, but should compare the next gain with its next cost.

The opening branch thus supplies a method for the whole curriculum. Define the endpoint. Identify the measure. Ask who chose it. Compare the cost of continuing with the cost of stopping. Then test whether the declared arrival serves the purpose that made the journey worth beginning.

Sources for this chapter: The unlinked opening questions belong to the [official WSC 2026 curriculum](#). For the economic mechanism, [Britannica Money on diminishing returns](#) helps distinguish a smaller marginal gain from an absolute loss. The curriculum correctly warns that the journey quotation is often misattributed; do not build an answer around a false Emerson attribution.

Chapter 2 - Endings that arrive in layers

Frank Sinatra's "My Way" and Peter Jackson's *The Lord of the Rings: The Return of the King* approach endings from opposite directions. The song begins by declaring that the end is near and compresses a whole life into a retrospective performance. The film appears to finish repeatedly because several intertwined journeys need different forms of closure. Together they show that an ending can be announced before it happens, experienced more than once, and judged differently depending on how much of the remaining route an audience can see.

"My Way" turns an ending into authorship

Sinatra recorded "My Way" in 1968 and released it in 1969. Paul Anka wrote its English words after hearing "Comme d'habitude," a 1967 French song associated with Claude Francois. The French song concerns the exhausted routine of a failing relationship. Anka retained the melody but created a different speaker: an older person near the end, looking back on choices, regrets, successes, and defeats while insisting that the life was lived on his own terms.

The official [L001 - "My Way" recording and lyrics video](#) matters because delivery changes meaning. The opening is controlled and reflective; the arrangement grows in force as the speaker converts a private review into a public claim. The song does not prove that the speaker's account is fair. "My way" can sound like courage, stubbornness, self-knowledge, or self-mythology. Other people affected by the same choices might tell a different story.

That ambiguity makes the song a useful model of a narrated ending. Near an endpoint, people do not simply remember events. They select and arrange them into a route. A graduation speech turns years of confusion into a lesson. A retiring leader presents setbacks as stages in a plan. A nation commemorates one date as the end of a war while violence and displacement continue. The narrative can create coherence, but it can also hide passengers who did not choose the driver's route.

The prompt pairs an ending with a point of no return. These are not identical. An ending is when a process stops or a new state is declared. A point of no return is an earlier threshold after which reversing course becomes impossible, unsafe, or prohibitively costly. The phrase has a literal aviation use: after a certain point, remaining fuel or conditions may make return to the departure airfield impossible. In life, signing a contract, publishing a message, or beginning a dangerous procedure can create a similar asymmetry. The consequences are not necessarily immediate, but the old route is no longer available in the same way.

A film can finish its mission before its people

The Return of the King was released in 2003. Its theatrical version runs a little over three hours and twenty minutes, while the extended edition is longer. The curriculum's "three and a half hours" is a reasonable description of the theatrical experience once trailers and cinema time are considered, but students should avoid treating it as an exact runtime for every edition.

The linked essay, [L002 - "In Defense of The Return of the King's Five Separate Endings"](#), argues that the apparent excess is structural. Destroying the Ring completes the central mission. Frodo and Sam's rescue closes the immediate survival crisis. Aragorn's coronation resolves a political restoration. The hobbits' return to the Shire brings travellers home. Frodo's departure acknowledges that homecoming does not erase trauma, while Sam's return to his family offers a quieter continuation. Counting exactly five endings is less important than noticing that each answers a different question.

This distinction appears far beyond film. A disease outbreak can reach a scientific threshold, an official emergency can end later, and grief can continue after both declarations. A competition finishes when the clock stops, but rankings, appeals, and memories persist. A peace agreement can end formal combat without completing reconstruction or reconciliation. Declaring one endpoint does not make the remaining ones fake.

How a progress display changes time

Many viewers in a cinema in 2003 did not have a visible playback bar. A scene that looked final could therefore create an expectation of closure, followed by surprise when another scene began. A streaming interface reveals the

remaining minutes. That information can reduce uncertainty, but it can also change attention. If only four minutes remain, a viewer may interpret a quiet shot as farewell. If forty minutes remain, the same shot feels transitional.

The principle applies to school years, hospital waits, speeches, elections, and friendships. A visible countdown can make waiting tolerable because uncertainty shrinks. It can also make every remaining minute feel slower. Hidden duration can preserve suspense, but it can feel manipulative when people have other obligations. The design question is ethical as well as aesthetic: what information does an audience or participant deserve about the time and stages still ahead?

These two works finally offer different versions of control. Sinatra's speaker claims control over the story of his route. Jackson's audience lacks control over the film's remaining length but receives closure for characters whose journeys no longer fit into one finish line. In both, "the end" is not a dot. It is a zone in which people interpret what has happened and decide what deserves to continue.

Sources for this chapter: Listen closely to [L001 - "My Way"](#) for the movement from reflection to self-assertion. Read [L002 - Bright Wall/Dark Room on the five endings](#) for the argument that each coda closes a different thread. A useful companion is [TIME's account of the song's French origin and later reuse at the Paris 2024 closing ceremony](#), another case in which an ending is staged for a public audience.

Chapter 3 - Living in the almost

Young Simba cannot wait to become king. Mid-century designers could not wait for nuclear cars and meals in pills. Both branches are about futures imagined before the conditions for them exist. The difference is that adolescence normally leads somewhere, while a predicted technology may remain "almost here" forever. Comparing them reveals why delay can be a necessary preparation in one case and evidence of a broken forecast in another.

Simba wants the privilege before the responsibility

In *The Lion King*, the official [L003 - "I Just Can't Wait to Be King" sequence](#) presents kingship through a child's imagination. Simba expects freedom from orders, universal attention, and the power to dismiss advice. Zazu's interruptions supply what the fantasy excludes: rules, duties, knowledge, and consequences. The staging becomes increasingly colourful and impossible, with animals arranged into a spectacle that literally places Simba above others. It is a performance of arrival before he has learned the job.

Adolescence is liminal, meaning it occupies a threshold between recognized states. Teenagers may have greater physical ability, knowledge, privacy, and independence than children while still lacking some legal rights, economic resources, or experience associated with adulthood. The boundary differs by society and by activity. A person may be old enough to work, consent to medical treatment, drive, vote, marry, or sign a contract at different ages. There is no single gate through which a complete adult emerges.

The in-between can feel frustrating because status and capacity develop unevenly. It can also be protective. Practice, education, mentorship, and gradually expanded freedom allow mistakes before the stakes become highest. Faster transition is not automatically kinder. If a society forces young people into adult labour or caregiving before they have support, an earlier arrival may remove childhood without delivering genuine power. Conversely, extending dependency without meaningful responsibility can prevent practice. A good threshold gives people increasing agency together with guidance and accountability.

Nuclear cars: the future defeated by mass

Cold War enthusiasm for peaceful atomic power produced striking concept vehicles. The [L004 - Smithsonian history of nuclear-powered cars](#) discusses the Ford Nucleon, the Studebaker-Packard Astral, and other designs from the late 1950s and early 1960s. Their promised range made petrol look obsolete. Yet they were mainly models and concepts, not nearly finished consumer vehicles.

The barrier was physical, not a shortage of dramatic styling. No reactor had been made small and safe enough for an ordinary car. Shielding passengers from radiation could make a vehicle weigh around fifty tons. Designers also faced crashes, security, cost, maintenance, and radioactive waste. A nuclear ship can place a large reactor inside a vast vessel managed by specialists. Millions of privately owned reactors moving through streets create a radically different risk system. The technology did not merely need one more clever component. Its proposed scale of use changed the problem.

Food pills: nutrition is not a file to compress

The [L005 - BBC history of the meal-in-a-pill dream](#) traces a fantasy older than space travel. A tiny tablet seemed to promise efficiency, freedom from cooking, and a solution to scarcity. Some late nineteenth-century predictions linked synthetic food to freeing women from unpaid kitchen labour. Science fiction later made the pill a sign that the future had eliminated inconvenient bodily routines.

A pill can deliver particular vitamins or medicines, but a complete meal contains far more energy and physical material than a capsule can hold. Human beings need macronutrients, fibre, water, and enough calories. Eating also performs social, sensory, and cultural work. A technology that supplies nutrients while removing taste, shared meals, agriculture, or choice has not simply improved food. It has redefined what food is for. Modern meal replacements are real and useful in some settings, but they do not make ordinary meals obsolete.

3D television: working is not the same as arriving

Three-dimensional television reached shops, so it differs from the nuclear car. Manufacturers promoted it heavily around 2010, helped by the success of 3D cinema. Yet home viewers often needed special glasses, compatible players, suitable content, careful seating, and expensive new displays. Glasses could be uncomfortable, households needed several pairs, and broadcasters faced the cost of producing or transmitting a limited catalogue. The extra depth did not provide enough value in everyday viewing to justify the inconvenience for most consumers.

This is a crucial innovation lesson. A prototype proves that something can function. Adoption requires it to fit budgets, habits, infrastructure, regulation, comfort, and competing alternatives. Forecasts often show the impressive object but hide the surrounding system. The same error appears when a demonstration of a flying car is treated as proof that cities are ready for noisy, regulated, weather-dependent fleets.

Simba and the abandoned futures therefore share impatience but teach different conclusions. A young person needs time because capability and responsibility are developing. A technology may need time, but repeated delay can reveal that the imagined destination was built on missing assumptions. Ask not only "when will it arrive?" Ask what work, risk, infrastructure, and behaviour the prediction has left outside the frame.

Sources for this chapter: Watch [L003 - Simba's "I Just Can't Wait to Be King"](#) as an argument about freedom and duty, not merely as a song. Read [L004 - Smithsonian on atomic cars](#) for the unresolved engineering system and [L005 - BBC Future on food pills](#) for the social history behind the fantasy. The [Henry Ford's Nucleon collection record](#) and [IEEE Spectrum's account of 3D television's failure](#) strengthen the difference between a concept, a functioning product, and durable adoption.

Chapter 4 - Why beginnings do not guarantee endings

A to-do list, a downloaded game, and a university enrolment all record beginnings. They create evidence of intention, not completion. This final branch asks why people commit to routes they do not finish and whether modern technology helps them persist or supplies more attractive exits. Its hardest lesson is that non-completion has more than one cause and more than one moral meaning.

The dangerous simplicity of a completion rate

The official [L006 - article on unfinished video games](#) reports industry expectations that a large majority of players will never see a game's ending. It discusses a widely repeated example in which only about ten percent of tracked players completed the final mission of *Red Dead Redemption*. That number is memorable, but it is not a universal law about every game or player.

Completion is difficult to measure. Some games offer a main story, optional quests, multiple endings, endless multiplayer play, or achievements beyond the final mission. Tracking may cover only particular platforms or connected users. A person can receive value from ten hours of play without reaching the credits. Others stop because the design becomes repetitive, the difficulty spikes, a new release competes for attention, friends move to another game, or adult responsibilities reduce available time. A low completion rate can reveal a problem, but it can also reveal that the product allows many kinds of use.

University statistics require even more caution because the consequences are larger. "Nearly half" depends on the country, institution, type of programme, cohort, time window, transfer rules, and definition of completion. In the United States, National Student Clearinghouse and NCES reports often follow cohorts for six or eight years and distinguish two-year from four-year institutions. A student who transfers may appear as a non-completer in one institution while eventually graduating elsewhere. Current figures should always be labelled by cohort and method.

The causes also extend beyond willpower. Tuition, housing, illness, disability, family care, discrimination, weak academic preparation, poor advising, employment, visa status, and an institution's flexibility can all affect completion. Treating every departure as laziness hides the structures that make the same route easier for some travellers than others. At the same time, support cannot remove every mismatch. A student may discover a better programme or decide that the expected return no longer justifies the cost.

Motivation changes while the route continues

Starting often feels rewarding because it produces an immediate identity: I am writing a novel, learning a language, getting fit, or playing an acclaimed game. The middle supplies fewer ceremonies. Progress becomes slower and obstacles reveal the real cost. Psychologists distinguish an intention from an implementation plan. "I will study more" describes a desired future. "At 7:00 p.m. on Tuesday, I will review chapter three at the library" creates a cue and action.

Large goals also hide the next move. "Finish the project" is not an action if the student still needs to choose a topic, find evidence, divide tasks, draft, edit, and submit. Breaking a route into visible stages reduces uncertainty and creates intermediate feedback. Yet milestones can become a performance of progress if people spend more time organizing tools than doing the work. A perfect colour-coded list is not the same as one completed task.

Social commitment helps when it provides accountability, shared knowledge, or encouragement. It hurts when a person remains on a bad route to avoid embarrassment. This is the sunk-cost trap: past time or money cannot be recovered, so the decision should compare future costs and benefits. Finishing a harmful or worthless project merely to protect the meaning of earlier effort adds a new loss. Responsible persistence includes the ability to stop deliberately.

Technology is both bridge and exit ramp

Digital tools can make completion easier. Calendars supply reminders. Collaborative documents preserve versions and show contributions. Learning platforms break courses into modules. Game interfaces show quests and save

progress. Accessibility tools reduce barriers. Online communities can connect a learner with explanations unavailable locally.

The same device offers messages, short videos, games, news, shopping, and an almost frictionless way to avoid discomfort. Platforms compete for attention with notifications and variable rewards. More choice can also weaken commitment: when hundreds of games or courses wait in a library, abandoning one feels cheap. Technology has not removed human agency, but it has redesigned the environment in which agency operates.

A useful response is not to call every interruption a moral failure. Change the route. Remove unnecessary notifications, make the next action small, schedule difficult work before attention is exhausted, and create a clear stopping rule. For group projects, name who owns each task, what "done" means, when work will be reviewed, and what happens if a stage is missed. A progress system should reveal reality rather than decorate hope.

When not finishing is the right arrival

Some unfinished journeys should be rescued. A student blocked by money or poor support may still value the destination and need a better path. Some should be redesigned because the original target was too large or vague. Others should end. A book that teaches nothing, a game that has stopped being enjoyable, or a goal chosen to impress someone else may not deserve completion.

The ethical test is not "Did you finish everything you started?" No one can. It is "Did you understand why you stopped, and did you take responsibility for the effects on others?" Quietly abandoning a shared task transfers the cost to teammates. Leaving an unsuitable private hobby does not. Completion is a useful measure only after purpose and obligation have been defined.

Sources for this chapter: Treat [L006 - "Why most people don't finish video games"](#) as an industry discussion with examples, not a universal completion statistic. Compare it with the [National Student Clearinghouse's cohort-based completion reporting](#) and the [US National Center for Education Statistics](#). The denominator, time window, transfers, and institution type belong in any responsible use of a percentage.

Final synthesis - Arrival is a judgement

The introduction to *Are We There Yet?* does not offer one definition of progress. It teaches how to examine a definition. A film can finish its mission while continuing to heal its characters. A song can announce an ending and turn it into a claim of authorship. Adolescence can be an uncomfortable delay and a necessary training ground. A technological future can function as a prototype yet fail as a system. A person can stop before the declared destination and still make a rational decision.

The connections are easiest to remember as a sequence. First define "there." Then choose evidence that movement toward it is real. Look for thresholds after which return becomes harder. Ask what the progress display reveals and what it conceals. When the destination is reached, test whether it served the original purpose and whether other people's journeys remain unfinished.

A weak answer says that the journey matters more than the destination or that persistence is always good. A stronger answer identifies the case in which each claim fails. Ambulances need arrival. Education needs experience along the route. Abandoning a teammate is irresponsible. Abandoning a harmful plan can be wise. The theme begins, appropriately, before it gets anywhere. Its first destination is a better question.